

billion more shares, and the over-the-counter markets listed another 30-or-so billion. Add to this the penny stocks and family companies traded in private, and there must be trillions of shares in every conceivable kind of enterprise. Most of these were either kept in a "fungible mass" by the brokerage houses (all the shares of all the customers lumped in an undifferentiated pile), or else stored separately in the safe-deposit boxes and closets of the nation.

In 1959, there were only 10 billion shares loose in the country, a fifth of what was now counted on the New York Stock Exchange alone. A century or so ago, there were a few million shares in everything from coast to coast. The printing of shares had been a very popular business, and more consequential than all our gold rushes and oil rushes combined.

Taken together, our shares in everything were worth several trillions. The companies traded on the New York Stock Exchange had a collective value that exceeded \$2 trillion, almost as big as our federal debt. Shares in companies on the American Stock Exchange were worth well over \$100 billion, and the over-the-counter market represented a third of a trillion worth of stock.

Not only were there more shares in our safe-deposit boxes and closets, but we also traded them more often. In fact, we frantically shuttled back and forth. More than 35 billion shares switched owners in the latest year at the NYSE. Many of these shares switched owners more than once. Since 51 billion shares were listed on the exchange as a whole, nearly three-fifths of all of them changed hands in a year. Another 28 billion shares were traded across the over-the-counter markets. Add these to the billions traded on the American Stock Exchange, and we reached an epidemic fickleness. And that was just in stocks.

How these facts fit in with the recorded message I heard in the visitor's gallery, that we'd abandoned "quick-dollar schemes" in favor of "savings-oriented vehicles concerned with long-term security," I couldn't begin to guess. If stocks were such good long-term investments, I wondered, then why didn't we stop trading them around and hold onto the ones we've got?

This last question was theoretical, of course. Personally, I was feeling more fickle than ever about Angstrom, and began to delight